

1. Type of Attack

The attack is a **phishing campaign that led to a ransomware infection**.

I think so because the employees received **spoofed HR emails** asking them to “update timesheets” and were redirected to a **fake login page** designed to steal credentials (phishing). The subsequent system-wide issue—where file-shares and Word documents could not open indicates that **malware, likely ransomware**, was executed on the network. This aligns with common ransomware symptoms such as **file encryption and access denial** (Infocyte, 2023; Emsisoft, 2023).

2. Next Steps as a Cybersecurity Analyst

As a cybersecurity analyst, these are the next steps I would take:

- **Isolate affected systems** immediately to prevent further spread across the network.
- **Disconnect infected devices** from shared drives and the internet.
- **Inform the incident response team and management** as per the organisation’s cyber incident response plan.
- **Preserve evidence** by securing logs, email headers, and forensic images for investigation.
- **Reset compromised user credentials** and enforce multi-factor authentication (MFA).
- **Notify employees** about the phishing attack to prevent additional clicks or downloads.

3. Containment, Resolution, and Recovery

Containment:

- Quarantine infected endpoints using endpoint detection and response (EDR) tools.
- Block malicious domains, IP addresses, and email senders at the firewall and email gateway.

Resolution:

- Run a **full malware scan** and remove all malicious executables.
- Patch exploited vulnerabilities and update antivirus signatures.
- Verify system integrity before reconnecting to the network.

Recovery:

- Restore encrypted or corrupted files from **secure, offline backups**.
- Test restored systems to confirm the absence of residual malware.
- Monitor network traffic for anomalies post-recovery.

4. Post-Incident Activities

- **Conduct a root cause analysis** to identify how the attack succeeded.
- **Prepare an incident report** summarising impact, timeline, and lessons learned.
- **Review and strengthen email filtering, user awareness, and MFA policies**

- **Provide phishing awareness training** to staff.
- **Update and test the incident response plan** to improve readiness for future attacks.

References:

Infocyte. (2023). *Top 10 Common Types of Cybersecurity Attacks*.

Panda Security. (2023). *11 Types of Phishing + Real-Life Examples*.

Emsisoft. (2023). *8 Critical Steps to Take After a Ransomware Attack*.

American University. (2023). *What to Do Before and After a Cybersecurity Breach*.